

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Clement Arockiasamy

A professor pauses mid-lecture. A slide remains half-explained, a thought suspended in the air. As a new academic year begins and campuses come alive once again, attention drifts not to the screen or the board, but to a student seated at the back, gazing out of the window. Is it disengagement, uncertainty, or a search for meaning that the lecture has not yet reached? In that fleeting moment, teaching reveals its deeper question: not what is being delivered, but what is truly being understood.

As colleges and universities reopen, beyond a return to schedules and syllabi and planning lectures lies a more fundamental inquiry: not just what we teach, but how and why we teach. Teaching cannot be measured solely by adherence to syllabus or method, nor only by outcomes such as grades or placements. It exists in the balance between what we aim to teach and what students truly carry forward.

Beyond content

For generations, the blackboard – and now the smart board – has symbolised structured instruction: clarity, authority, direction. Yet in a world of abundant information, students no longer depend solely on teachers for access to knowledge. The educator's role has expanded from delivering in-



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Beyond the board

Reimagining teaching in higher education at the beginning of a new academic year

formation to cultivating inquiry, from providing answers to framing meaningful questions. If higher education were only about degrees and employability, information delivery would suffice. But its purpose extends to preparing individuals to engage critically with ideas, navigate complexity, and contribute thoughtfully to society. A lecturer may transmit knowledge, but an educator shapes perspective. Within the university ecosystem, the teacher re-

mains closest to the student's intellectual journey. A single question, a moment of encouragement, or even a passing remark can shape how a student thinks long after the semester ends. As we look ahead to a future shaped by AI and constant change, certain capacities remain essential: critical thinking, communication, collaboration, and creativity. Students today navigate academic pressure, social comparison, and digital distraction. Classrooms

must, therefore, become spaces where students feel respected, heard, and intellectually safe. Among all teaching skills, listening is the most vital. It is through listening that educators understand what students grasp, what they question, and what remains unspoken. Intellectual investment This broader vision also calls for a renewed commitment to intellectual depth on the part of educators. Lecturers who invest

in books, read beyond the syllabus, engage with diverse authors, and bring fresh perspectives into the classroom make a quiet but powerful academic investment. When students encounter ideas that go beyond the expected text, learning becomes less about coverage and more about discovery. In many lecture halls, the challenge is not a lack of content, but a lack of engagement. The quiet student at the back – often seen as inattentive – may

reflect a deeper disconnect. Addressing this requires inclusive practices that draw in every learner. Even language matters: a word of encouragement can invite participation, while a careless remark can silence it. The debate between memorisation and understanding remains relevant. Education must move beyond repetition toward application, analysis, and reflection. Effective teaching rests on a balance between content, pedagogy, and the learner. An overloaded syllabus can restrict exploration, while excessive focus on method can dilute clarity. The student must remain at the centre, not as a passive recipient but as an active participant. Teaching also involves knowing when to step back. As students grow, the educator's role evolves from instructor to facilitator, from guide to collaborator. Ultimately, a teacher in higher education is also a mentor, a catalyst for inquiry, and a quiet influence on how students come to see the world. The true measure of education lies not in what is written or displayed, but in what endures. Perhaps that student at the back is not disengaged at all but simply waiting for a reason to look up.

The writer is a Chevening Scholar, a graduate from the Institute of Development Studies at the University of Sussex, U.K., and a teacher trainer.

SCHOLARSHIPS

IDFC FIRST Bank MBA Scholarship

Offered by IDFC FIRST Bank. **Eligibility:** Indian nationals residing in India and enrolled in the first year of a two-year full-time MBA programme in one of the 46 MBA colleges (check link below) with an annual family income not exceeding ₹600,000 from all sources. Applicants must have a valid mobile number linked to their Aadhaar number. **Rewards:** ₹100,000 for each year of study **Application:** Online **Deadline:** July 8 www.b4s.in/edge/IFBMS7

AICTE Saksham Scholarship for Specially Abled Students

Offered by the All India Council for Technical Education. **Eligibility:** Indian nationals from the specially-abled categories with a benchmark disability of 40% or more who have secured admission into a degree or diploma programme in AICTE-approved institutions in the current academic year and have an annual family income not exceeding not exceeding ₹800,000. **Rewards:** ₹50,000 a year **Application:** Online **Deadline:** October 31 www.b4s.in/edge/ASSST4

Courtesy: Buddy4study

AI Adoption Survey

QS I-GAUGE has launched an AI Adoption Survey for Educators, to assess educators' perceptions of AI, their current usage patterns, and readiness to adopt AI in professional roles. The findings are expected to provide valuable national-level insights into how educational institutions can responsibly, effectively, and ethically integrate AI into academic ecosystems, even as AI

continues to reshape teaching, learning, assessment, research, and administrative functions. **Who can participate:** Faculty members from schools across all educational boards, colleges, universities and other higher education institutions across India. **How to participate** Teachers from schools can visit <https://survey.zoho.com/public/in/zs/jmBMY6> Faculty from higher education institutions can visit <https://survey.zoho.com/public/in/zs/yzBMBR>



OFF THE EDGE Nandini Raman

I am a research scholar in angiosperm taxonomy. If I want to do a postdoc abroad, which countries/institutes should I consider? What are my job options in India? Athira

Dear Athira, To be competitive for a postdoc abroad, build skills in Molecular Phylogenetics (DNA extraction, NGS, RAXML, BEAST), GIS and Remote Sensing (QGIS, ArcGIS), and R Programming. Identify a professor whose research aligns with yours and approach them with a tailored proposal. Funding agencies such as JSPS, Marie Curie, and Fulbright often require a host supervisor before application. The U.K. remains a major centre for plant taxonomy. The Royal Botanic Gardens in Kew and Edinburgh are internationally renowned, while Oxford and Cambridge have strong programmes in systematics and evolutionary biology. Other options are the Missouri Botanical Garden, New York Botanical Garden, Smithsonian Institution, and the Harvard University Herbaria in the U.S.; Berlin-Dahlem Botanical Garden, Germany; the Naturalis Biodiversity Centre, the Netherlands; and Kunming Institute of Botany and South China Botanical Garden, China. In India, look at the Botanical Survey of India, CSIR institutes, ICFRE institutes and NBPGR. Private-sector openings exist in herbal, biotech, and environmental consulting companies.

I am in Class 12 (Commerce). I enjoy Business Studies and Management, but do not like Accountancy or calculation-heavy

Bridge the gaps

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

subjects. Should I do a BBA or B.Com? Parvathy

Dear Parvathy, Since you enjoy the strategic and people-oriented aspects of Business Studies, a BBA with a specialisation in Marketing or HR will be a good choice. While it includes basic statistics and mathematics, the emphasis is on interpreting data rather than recording it. Given your dislike for Accountancy, BBA is likely a better fit for three reasons. First, it is generally more qualitative than quantitative. Second, it offers diverse specialisations such as Human Resource Management, Marketing, International Business and Digital Media Management. Third, much of the learning is based on analysing real-world business challenges. The most common progression after BBA is an MBA, leading to careers in Sales, Brand Management, HR, or Corporate Communications. Look for universities offering Liberal Arts-style BBA programmes, such as FLAME, Shiv Nadar or Symbiosis. These allow greater flexibility in choosing creative electives. My brother is studying B.A. Economics in Tamil Medium. In his first year, he passed all his papers except English. How can he improve? Also, how can he get a part-time job, as he lives in a government hostel? Pasupati

Dear Pasupati, The key is to bridge the language gap. Ask him to collect the question papers of the past five years and practise recurring grammar

topics and paragraph writing. Every day, he should: (i) read a short English paragraph and mentally translate it into Tamil; (ii) write five simple sentences about his day in English; and (iii) listen to English news or podcasts for 10 minutes to become familiar with pronunciation and sentence structure. He can watch YouTube channels like Possible English, which explain grammar using Tamil examples. For part-time work, if he has good computer skills, he could look for jobs near his hostel involving typing, photocopying, document filing, billing or customer service. He can also explore freelance translation of educational or economic content from English to Tamil. If he owns a two-wheeler, delivery platforms offer flexible evening shifts. Opportunities at offices or nearby establishments as an assistant or supervisor may also be worth exploring. He can also check the Naan Mudhalvan portal, which offers skill-development programmes, including English and digital skills, often linked to internships or stipends. Since he is staying in a government hostel, ensure his details are updated on the TNPMIS portal for the Post-Matric Scholarship. The Tamil Nadu Skill Development Corporation (TNSDC) also offers vocational courses with small training stipends.

I finished PG Physics in 2023 and began to prepare for banking exams but am still unemployed. I am not interested in teaching or research. How can I

rebuild my career? Aiswarya

Dear Aiswarya, The goal is to link your Physics degree to the technology and business sectors. A Data Science certification, such as IIT-Madras' online BS/Diploma in Data Science, is a strong option, as it is well recognised. If financial risk interests you, consider the Financial Risk Manager (FRM) certification. For operations and supply chain management, the APICS CPIM certification is highly valued. For Data Analyst or Business Analyst roles, start learning Advanced Excel and SQL and follow with Python or Tableau. Technical Writing and Intellectual Property (IP) can also be options. Patent firms such as Sagacious IP and Clarivate hire Physics postgraduates to analyse inventions and prepare technical documentation. Strong English skills are an advantage here. Physics graduates are also recruited for Quality Control (QC) and Non-Destructive Testing (NDT) roles in industries such as automotive, aerospace and manufacturing. To strengthen your resume, take up a current role such as a Subject Matter Expert (SME) with ed-tech platforms. You can also explore back-office operations roles in fintech companies, which value analytical thinking and scientific training. Additionally, internships with NITI Aayog or other government organisations involving data-driven policy research can help address employment gaps and enhance your profile. Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

Ramya Venkataraman

Higher education is increasingly coming under pressure to rethink what it is preparing students for, and how. In India, that question matters even more because secondary education is no longer one uniform story. There are now two very distinct worlds. In one, applied exposure, experimentation, and early career imagination are starting to come in, whether inside schools or through parallel avenues outside them. In the other, students remain in a system that is still centred around preparing for exams that are themselves not fully competency-based, let alone aligned with the real world and workplaces of the future. Even the conditions for applied exposure remain uneven. Official UDISE+ data for 2024-25 shows that only 63.5% of schools had Internet access.

What is interesting is that the higher education landscape is not adequately prepared for either cohort. For the first, the return to passive note-taking and rigid academic structures can feel like an immediate disconnect. For the second, the gap they already face in relation to the workplace often becomes even more pronounced during undergraduate study.

Visible pathways

Coming back to the first cohort, by Class 11 or 12, many have already built prototypes, entered innovation challenges or written basic code. They may not yet be experts but are no longer passive recipients of theory. They expect to understand how concepts connect to real-world problems. This shift matters deeply because secondary school is where career aspirations begin to take shape. Universities are meant to be the bridge between early exposure and long-term



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career clarity. But that bridge is uneven right now. India's higher education system largely continues to operate on a lecture-and-exam model. While foundational concepts are essential, the key issue lies in sequencing and pedagogy. As secondary schools start trying to introduce applied learning early, universities must build upward from that base, not restart at zero. While some IITs are experimenting with project-based structures and a few private universities have redesigned the first-year experience around interdisciplinary problem-solving, across India's 1,100-plus universities and 43,000 colleges, change remains insufficient. For either cohort, universities cannot afford to postpone career conversations until placement season. Students now encounter emerging fields before they choose undergraduate streams. For the ones with early exposure, delay can mean losing momentum. Those without it lose valuable time to build awareness, confidence, and direction.

Universities need to make pathways visible much earlier. Diagnostic assessments can help understand prior exposure and identify where students are starting from. Structured mentoring can begin in the first year. Modular specialisation tracks can provide direction without forcing premature choices. Industry-linked projects from the second year can help students connect learning with possible roles and sectors. Career clarity should evolve continuously in ways that respond to different types of starting points.

Change assessments

Secondary and senior secondary STEM programmes increasingly use project submissions, portfolios, peer review and prototype evaluation. Even Board exams are starting to rethink methods of evaluation and how to become more 'competency-based'. Yet many universities still rely almost entirely on three-hour written examinations. Higher education needs to urgently adopt competency-based assessments,

capstone projects evaluated by external experts, and portfolio-driven evaluation, at scale. These approaches are particularly important in higher education, which is closest to the workplace.

The faculty question

At the heart of this transition is teacher capability. For example, secondary reforms require significant teacher upskilling in experiential pedagogy, competency-based assessments, and mentoring innovation projects. Higher education faces a similar challenge. With an estimated 35-40% vacancy rate in public university faculty positions, and many existing faculty trained in traditional lecture models, the system needs structured support. If applied curricula are introduced but delivered through old pedagogies, the promise will weaken. Professional development for university faculty in project facilitation, interdisciplinary design, industry collaboration, and modern assessment is essential. Without it, even well-designed reforms will struggle in implementation. Both secondary and higher education remain uneven in quality, access, and relevance, even as important reforms and pockets of innovation emerge within each. This accentuates the problem of continuity. Students enter undergraduate education from very different starting points but higher education often responds as if they are all beginning from the same place. That weakens the bridge between school, deeper learning, and the workplace. If India wants early exposure and aspiration to translate into meaningful capability and career direction, the undergraduate continuum needs much more deliberate attention.

The writer is the founder and CEO of Centre for Teacher Accreditation (CENTA).

Lessons from a music room

What higher education can learn from music about teaching and feedback

Anil Srinivasan

Every serious music student has spent time in a practice room that felt less like a room and more like a mirror. A phrase is played, it falls short, it is played again. The teacher stops the student mid-bar, not to discourage, but because the error has a name and naming it is the first act of repair.

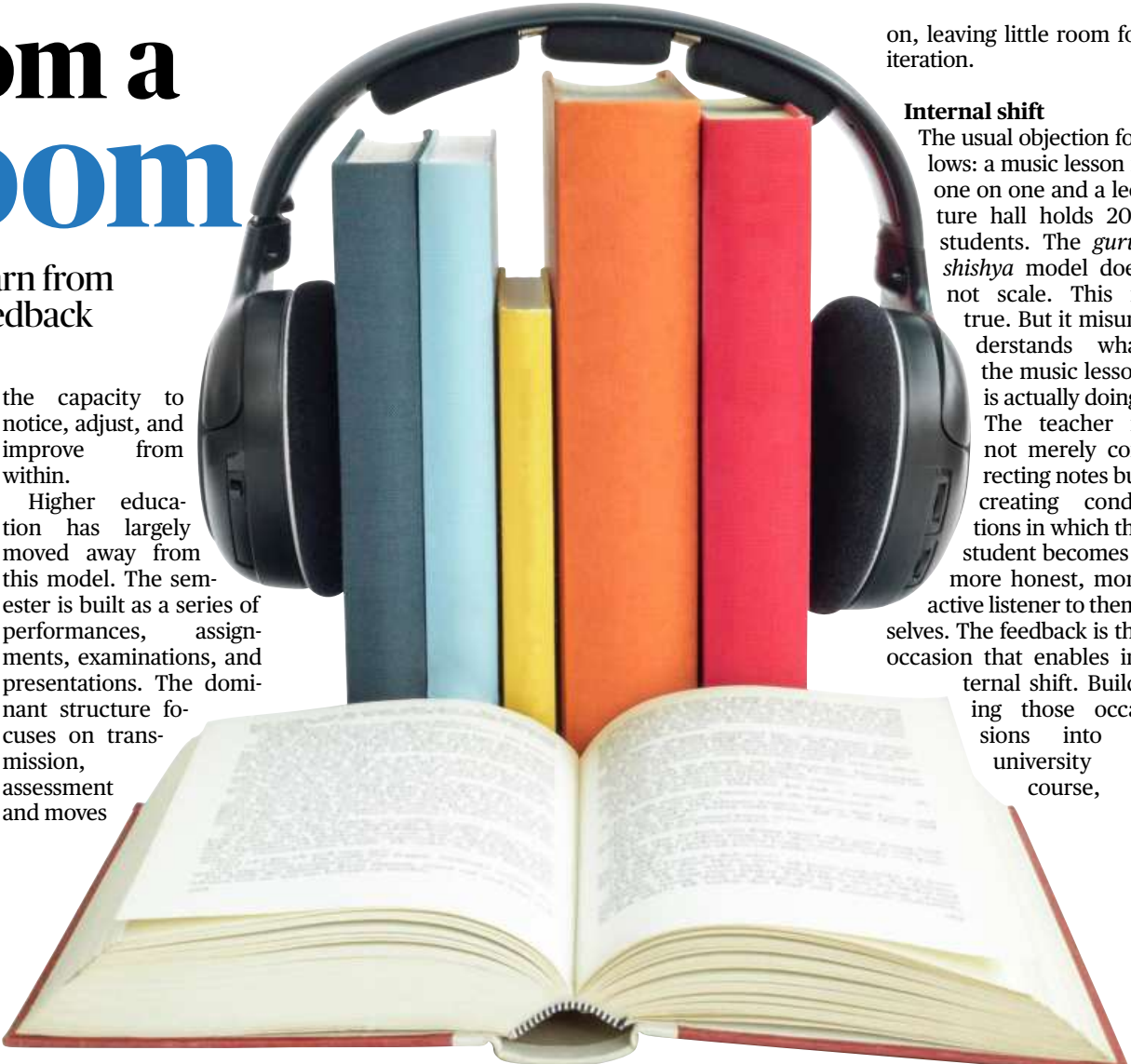
This exchange has been quietly repeated across music classrooms for centuries, holding a lesson that higher education is still in the process of fully absorbing, not in the content of music, but in the structure of how it is taught. The parallel worth drawing is specific: feedback. Not feedback as com-

monly practised in higher education; a grade that may be returned few weeks after submission or comments in the margin that arrive too late to change or shape something new. Feedback in music has always been understood, immediate, iterative and embedded in the act of learning itself.

In the Carnatic tradition, the *shishya* repeats and the *guru* corrects, not once but hundreds of times on a single phrase. This is not a sign of failure or inadequacy but the method. The student learns to hear the gap between what they produce and what they intend. Over time, they internalise the corrective voice. They begin to self-assess in real time. What is being trained is not just technique. It is

the capacity to notice, adjust, and improve from within.

Higher education has largely moved away from this model. The semester is built as a series of performances, assignments, examinations, and presentations. The dominant structure focuses on transmission, assessment and moves



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on, leaving little room for iteration.

Internal shift

The usual objection follows: a music lesson is one on one and a lecture hall holds 200 students. The *guru-shishya* model does not scale. This is true. But it misunderstands what the music lesson is actually doing. The teacher is not merely correcting notes but creating conditions in which the student becomes a more honest, more active listener to themselves. The feedback is the occasion that enables internal shift. Building those occasions into a university course,

through low-stakes retrieval, revision cycles, and structured peer critique offers a meaningful opportunity to enhance the learning process.

The evidence from learning science is unambiguous. Retrieval practice, spaced repetition, and formative feedback reliably outperform a single high-stakes assessment. While these insights have been known for decades, their integration across universities into course designs is still evolving. Music has been following these principles that research now affirms, shaped by the demands of practice rather than theory. When a student is stuck and cannot play a phrase, the gap is quite clear, making timely, responsive feedback a natural part of learning. This process also naturally guides teacher and student towards improvement.

There is a second lesson from the practice room that deserves equal attention: the value of the pause. Growth in music does not occur during practice alone; it often takes shape later, in the intervals that follow, in the rest and reflection between rehearsal and break-

through, when learning has the space to settle. How memory consolidates and skills deepen has been well documented. In higher education, as the semesters become more compressed and continuous, there is limited room for pauses and reflection. This must be changed over time for the benefit of both students and teachers.

If there is one structural shift that music education asks of higher education, it is this. Design the course as a practice room and treat students not as an audience receiving expertise but as active learners who are given a safe space to make mistakes, to be corrected, and to try again. The goal is not simply that a student completes the course, but that they pass with flying colours enabling them to do more than they could do before.

The music room has always known this. Lecture halls can incorporate certain elements of this approach to make the learning process more interesting and effective.

The writer is the founder of Rhapsody - Education Through Music and Kruu, an experiential learning platform .

Beyond the GDP

Why conversations around equity, ethical technology, and sustainable development must be an integral part of all disciplines

Meena Chintamaneni

For decades, Gross Domestic Product (GDP) has been the benchmark to measure a nation's progress. Rising GDP rates are correlated with prosperity, development, and economic growth. However, today, benchmarks like quality of life, social development, overall well-being, environmental stability, ethical technology, and social equity are just as important for a country's development.

Reports such as Oxfam's *Takers Not Makers: The Unjust Poverty and Unearned Wealth of Colonial Inheritance* and the UNDP's Human Development Index suggest that countries with strong healthcare, education, and social welfare systems rank higher in human development despite their GDP numbers. India, despite being one of the fastest-growing economies in the world, currently ranks 130 out of 193 in the HDI ranking. Therefore, it is time that the 'Beyond the GDP' conversation moves into Indian classrooms.

Modern challenges

Today's graduates face critical challenges such as climate change, the ethical use of AI, social inequality, resource constraints, and public welfare. Most of these cannot be solved by economic growth alone. These issues require empathy, innovation, social responsibility, and interdisciplinary collaborations. In a country like India, with its diverse demography and socioeconomic contrast, the

conversations that go beyond the GDP cannot be just one elective course in the first year; they have to be an important part of every course across every institution. COVID-19 taught us all about adaptability and resilience and highlighted the importance of emotional and mental well-being.

These life lessons make it imperative that classrooms move beyond traditional learning and help students develop the skills they need to navigate uncertainty and dynamic change. Business students, for example, must learn about ethical entrepreneurship and sustainable business practices, and ask hard questions on ethics, sustainability and social leadership. Engineering students must be taught to study the implications of AI systems and technology on employability and how they widen social gaps. A UNDP report, *A Matter of Choice: People and Possibilities in the Age of AI*, focuses on the need for inclusive policies so that technologies like AI reduce inequalities instead of aggravating them. Healthcare students must discuss accessibility and public welfare while media students need to understand social responsibility and the impact of misinformation. Essentially, these discussions will help students understand the interconnections between economic, social, technological, and environmental factors.

Measuring progress

Around the world, countries are reconsidering how progress should be

measured. Global frameworks like Gross National Happiness, Human Development Index, Sustainable Development Goals (SDG), and Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) policies reflect that development must be wholesome, inclusive, and sustainable. Countries like Denmark, Finland, Norway, Iceland, and Sweden rank high across these benchmarks due to high quality healthcare and education, social equality, and ethical governance, and the adoption of modern policies.

Indian classrooms must prepare and encourage students to ask questions such as: How can development be more sustainable? Who benefits from growth? Is innovation actually inclusive? Does technology improve the lives of all sections of society? These discussions are not about replacing growth-oriented thinking or neglecting economics, but about focusing on the broader understanding of community well-being.

While GDP is and will always be an important indicator of economic growth, judging a country just by its economic growth is not enough. The world does not care only about how a country grows economically, but about how its people live, how they thrive, and how they contribute to society. This conversation needs to start in the classroom.

The writer is Acting Vice Chancellor and Pro Vice Chancellor, SVKM's NMIMS Deemed-to-be-University.



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Jaskiran Arora

At the QS India Summit in Goa earlier this year, I found myself both amazed and unsettled by an insight shared by Martín Serrano, Director of Product Innovation at QS Employability. The session – AI, Skills and the Future of Work in Higher Education – presented findings from a study analysing more than 283,216 Business school syllabi worldwide and comparing them with over 2.3 million job postings to understand how closely the curricula aligned with industry demands.

What struck me was not merely the scale of the study but its central comparison. On the one hand were industry-relevance scores derived from job postings that revealed the skills employers value most. On the other hand was the proportion of syllabi explicitly referencing those same skills; an imperfect but useful proxy for how consciously curricula is designed to develop them.

Intentional or incidental?

What was truly disquieting was that two skills – adaptability and self-motivation – ranked very high in industry relevance but appeared far less frequently as explicit learning outcomes in formal

Teaching what matters

Education cannot prepare students for every challenge they will encounter. But it can prepare them to face challenges they cannot yet foresee

curriculum documents. While this does not necessarily mean they are being ignored, their relative absence as explicit design priorities raises an important question: are these skills being cultivated intentionally or emerging incidentally?

In earlier eras, changes were incremental and the pace of development kept knowledge relevant for many years. Today, technological developments and global interconnectedness are reshaping our world at an unprecedented pace and the greatest risk is not what one does not know, but one's inability to learn, unlearn, and relearn.

If adaptability allows individuals to respond to change, self-motivation determines whether individuals take the initiative to act and grow. The future of work is less linear and more self-directed. Therefore, both adaptability and self-motivation allow individuals to not only apply existing knowledge but also to extend, revise, and reinvent themselves as professionals.

Adaptability develops when learners encounter



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uncertainty, when they must rethink their assumptions, and when they don't necessarily find solutions.

Similarly, self-motivation develops when learners are given ownership. When outcomes depend not on compliance but on commitment. This happens when learning stops being something done 'to' students and becomes something driven 'by' them.

It is here that the responsibility of educational institutions becomes urgent and profound. Programmes that expose students to uncertain problems, interdisciplinary challenges, real-world constraints, and reflective practice create conditions in which adaptability and self-motivation can develop more deliberately. Internships, live projects,

entrepreneurial experiences, research opportunities, and community engagement initiatives are not merely supplementary activities. When thoughtfully designed, they become central mechanisms for learners to develop agency.

Roadblocks

However, these approaches also present institutional challenges. They need an explicit curriculum design that shapes learning experiences, assessment methods, and faculty intent, and does not leave the development of these skills to chance or an incidental by-product.

They require faculty to move beyond content delivery into facilitation. They complicate assessments. They demand

greater flexibility from curriculum structures that have traditionally prioritised standardisation and coverage.

These challenges are real and they help explain why such capabilities may be under-represented in formal curriculum articulation, even when institutions recognise their importance. Yet the urgency of the present moment suggests that education must address this gap by consciously nurturing a space where active learning design encourages ownership, reflection, and engagement beyond the classroom and create a vibrant, self-reflective ecosystem as an integral part of the teaching and learning philosophy.

In such spaces, learners stop asking, "What do I need to know?" and begin asking, "What kind of person must I become?" Perhaps that is where the answer to the question "Are we teaching what matters?" ultimately lies.

Education cannot prepare students for every challenge they will encounter. But it can prepare them to face challenges they cannot yet foresee. It can cultivate the capacity to adapt. The initiative to act. The confidence to navigate uncertainty with purpose. That is what will matter most.

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what each line does. Once a working solution has been generated, the student can ask the AI for alternative ways to solve the same problem to learn more efficient methods. To avoid the "blank page syndrome", teachers can suggest that students ask for a step-by-step logic outline (pseudo-code) rather than the final code.

Interactive learning:

Treat ChatGPT as a virtual tutor to discuss, brainstorm, or clarify technical concepts by asking for step-by-step explanations rather than just final answers. Students can be guided to use AI for deeper comprehension through explaining complex technical concepts (like "JavaScript scope" or "recursion") in simple terms or through analogies and to generate practice quizzes or coding challenges to test their knowledge.

Critical evaluation:

Ask students to critically evaluate, test, and verify AI-generated code or infor-

mation for accuracy and bias. This involves tasks in which students generate an answer using AI and find evidence to support or debunk it using official documentation. Another way is to have students compare a human-written solution to an AI-generated one to identify nuances, subtle errors, or creative touches the AI missed.

Ethical use and verification: To emphasise that AI is a tool to support, not replace, their learning, get students to compare output with documentation or other credible sources. Be specific about when AI is allowed (for example, brainstorming, debugging) and when it isn't (core assessment tasks). Require students to document how they used AI by keeping a log of prompts, interactions, and modifications to understand how to improve their interaction and to foster transparency and responsible use.

Collaborative tutor

How teachers can help students use AI to upgrade their skills

fining, in which students understand that the first answer is often just a starting point and that they should learn to ask follow-up questions.

Debugging assistance: Encourage students to paste error messages into ChatGPT, asking it to explain the error and suggest

fixes. This teaches troubleshooting skills.

Code explanation and optimisation:

Use ChatGPT to explain complex code snippets or suggest more efficient, optimised versions of student code. Have students input confusing code snippets and ask the AI to explain